SWACHH BHARAT MISSION

Cholera, polio, typhoid, hepatitis...India had long grappled with an embarrassing richness of diseases that spread through the faecal-oral route because of poor sanitation in the country. And children below the age of five bore the brunt of these diseases. In 2014, India's infant mortality ratio (IMR) stood at 38 per 1,000 live births and the under-5 mortality rate (U5MR) at 45. Today, IMR stands reduced to 28, while U5MR was 32 in 2020. And a recent study published in the journal *Nature,* which analysed data from 35 Indian states and 640 districts between 2011 and 2020, attributes it to one factor: the Swachh Bharat Mission. Announced by Narendra Modi soon after he became prime minister in 2014, the more than 100 million toilets built under this project have helped India avert close to 60,000-70,000 child deaths, according to the study.

There had been cleanliness missions before it—the Central Rural Sanitation Programme in 1954, the Total Sanitation Campaign in 1999, and the Nirmal Bharat Abhiyaan in 2012. But none caught the imagination of the country like Swachh Bharat. Behind its success lies the strong political will and leadership of the prime minister himself, who made it a personal mission of sorts. The programme was given a vast ambition— eliminating open defecation, improving unsanitary toilets, eradicating manual scavenging, improving solid waste management, and changing attitudes towards hygiene and cleanliness. It was also backed up with incentive—Rs 10,000 (later enhanced to Rs 12,000) to build individual household latrines for rural households.

The Centre also opened its purse for the purpose, allocating Rs 83,937 crore on SBM Gramin (rural) from 2014-2022 and Rs 13,329 crore for SBM Urban until 2021. Technology was deployed to achieve measurable outcomes, and corporates roped in to make it part of their CSR initiatives. Along with access to toilets, SBM's challenge was also to get people to use them. Enter Amitabh Bachchan, Sachin Tendulkar and other celebrity and community influencers to use their persuasion skills.

At the end of the first phase of Swachh Bharat, most states were reported to have achieved 100 per cent open defecation free (ODF) status, according to the Economic Survey 2018-19. The risk of groundwater contamination in ODF villages was found to be 12.7 times lower; 78 per cent of the waste was processed. Access to toilet facilities also improved significantly, with 82.5 per cent of households reporting access in 2019-21, from 45 per cent in 2004-05. ■

HIGH ON HYGIENE

» Households in ODF villages report annual health-related savings of around Rs 50,000

» Women have found employment as 'rani mistris' after getting trained as masons who can build toilets in their communities

» Incidents of sexual violence against women have come down as they no longer have to wait until dark to relieve themselves in the open

» No toilet, no bride. Women refuse to marry grooms unless they build toilets in the house

DID YOU KNOW?

Over 3 mn govt employees, 1.2 mn school and college students, 625,000 volunteers, 250,000 panchayat leaders, lakhs of public and 50 celebrities are involved in the movement



FROM THE ARCHIVES
Oct. 13, 2014

Cover Story **Dirty Nation**

India's famous lack of hygiene is puzzling to those used to piped water and plumbed toilets. Why is the rest of the country such a filthy embarrassment, wonder civic-minded middle-class Indians.

But why does it take a small army of sanitation workers to tend to toilets in hotels, malls and workplaces? The disregard for public cleanliness is not confined to one class; it is just the fog we live in.

-Amulya Gopalakrishnan

82.5%
HOUSEHOLDS
Reported access to toilet facilities in 2019-21, almost double the 45 per cent in 2004-05